

THE
 ROCK PAINTINGS
OF THE CHUMASH
A Study of a California Indian Culture

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University of California Press
Berkeley and Los Angeles
1966

40097

San Nicolás Island

South and southeast of the Santa Barbara Channel Islands are four more islands. The three largest are Santa Catalina, San Clemente, and San Nicolás, all of which had permanent settlements. The smallest, Santa Barbara Island, was used intermittently, probably as a fishing camp. All of these islands were in the territory of the Shoshonean-speaking Gabrieliño.

San Nicolás lies about 65 miles from the nearest shore and has been a source of very fine artifacts, perhaps the finest that have been taken from the Chumash-Gabrieliño region.

All we know of the culture of the historic San Nicolás islanders comes from the accounts of the lost woman of San Nicolás, a Crusoe-like tale of an Indian woman, abandoned for eighteen years on the island. As the story includes the only detailed eye-witness account of the way of life of a Channel Island Indian, it is worth retelling.

In 1811, a Boston trading vessel took a party of Kodiak Indians from Sitka in Russian America to San Nicolás to hunt otter. They were left on the island for a period of months while the ship went south to Baja California. There was fighting with the native islanders over the women, and many men were killed by the Kodiaks. When the otter hunters were picked up by their ship, all contact with the island was broken for twenty-four years.

In 1835, a schooner with the unhappy name of *Peor es Nada* ("Worse Than Nothing") sailed from Santa Barbara on an otter hunt in Baja California.

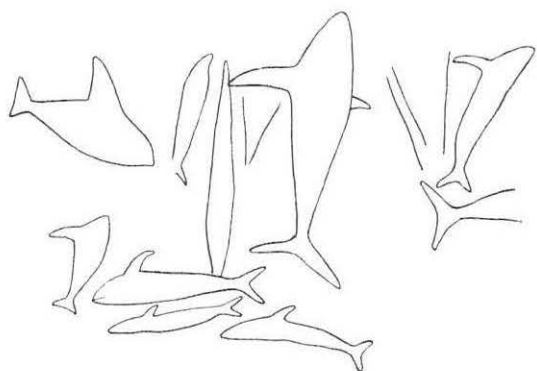


FIGURE 120.
Petroglyphs of killer whales from a
cave on San Nicolás Island. (After
Reinman and Townsend, 1960)

Aboard was a trapper from the Rocky Mountains named Bill Williams.¹ Three months later the crew put in at San Pedro and were given a special job by the local missionaries. The Franciscans were scraping the bottom of the heathen barrel, and the church decided to remove the remnants of the San Nicolás islanders to the mainland. The *Peor es Nada* sailed for San Nicolás with instructions to round up all Indians and bring them back to San Pedro.

This turned out to be a simple enough job. Between the Kodiak massacre and the diseases left by otter hunters, there were only eighteen Indians left. One, a young woman, was left behind because she had gone looking for her child. Due to the stormy weather, the schooner could not wait for her and sailed for the mainland. The "rescued" Indians were sent to Los Angeles and Mission San Gabriel. It was the intention to send the ship back to pick up the missing woman, but the *Peor es Nada* was sunk soon after, and no attempt was made to look for her until 1850. That year a search was made on San Nicolás for the woman. No trace of her was found and all thought of further search was abandoned. In 1852, George Nidever, a fur trapper who had come to California with the famous Walker exploration party in 1833, sailed to San Nicolás with an Indian crew to look for sea-gull eggs, which were in great demand locally. They saw fresh footprints near some brush huts but before they could carry out a search, one of the savage northwesterners hit them. After eight days of storm, they sailed for the mainland and reported signs of the missing Indian.

¹There is a possibility this may have been the almost legendary mountain man, Bill Williams. In 1833 Joseph Reddeford Walker was sent by Captain Bonneville to explore the country to the west of the Great Salt Lake. With him went a party of over forty seasoned trappers including Alexis Godey, Bill Williams, Zenas Leonard, George Nidever, and Joe Meek. The party reached California, discovering the Yosemite Valley on the way, and wintered at Monterey. Most of these men returned to the Rockies but several, including Nidever, stayed in California. It is known that Williams and others returned to California on a number of occasions, attracted by the ease of horse stealing from the big ranchos and missions. In writing of the Bill Williams who went with the *Peor es Nada* to San Nicolás, Nidever wrote, "I remember distinctly . . . a man named Williams, a former acquaintance of mine in the Rocky Mountains. . . . Williams of the Chino Ranch in Los Angeles County, and who was with me in the Mts., he with Col. Bean having shown the white feather in our first engagement with the Indians on the Ark. River. He afterwards took one of the Indian women [from San Nicolás] to live with."

The following winter, Nidever returned to San Nicolás to hunt otter. He had instructions from Father Gonzales to make every effort to find the woman. Soon after landing, they again saw fresh footprints in the sand and numbers of wild dogs. In a bush, they found a basket, covered with a piece of seal skin. In the basket were several bird skins, cut square, a long twisted sinew rope and some bone needles. They spread the contents around on the ground with the intention of seeing if they were replaced at a later visit. Again a storm came up and they returned to Santa Barbara.

The next spring, Nidever sailed for San Nicolás, prepared to stay several months. They found a good spring near the western end of the island with human footprints around it. They relocated the basket and found that it had been refilled with its contents and hung on a bush. By following the footprints, the woman was seen near some huts made of whale ribs and brush. She was stripping blubber from a piece of sealskin as she watched the hunters closing in on her. She showed no sign of fear and chattered away at the Chumash crewmen in an unintelligible language. After a while she roasted some roots on the fire in the shelter and offered them to her visitors. Blubber was drying on stakes and suspended from sinew ropes. There were a number of baskets nearby, some in various stages of manufacture, and two bottle-shaped water baskets. Other articles were fishhooks and needles of bone, fishing lines of sinew, and a large rope for snaring sleeping seals.

The woman was about 50 years of age, of medium height and rather stocky. Her dress was made of cormorant skins, sleeveless, tied at the waist with a cord and reaching to the ground. She indicated that during the rainy season she lived in a nearby cave. Nidever, by sign language, told the woman they had come to take her away, and she at once packed up her belongings in baskets, including a very ripe seal's head, and followed the men to a spring near shore where her things were left. She was then taken aboard the schooner and given a meal of hardtack and beans, which she ate with relish.

The following day, the otter hunters set up a camp near the middle of the island and the Indian woman kept the camp supplied with wood and with water, which she carried in her water baskets. Nidever saw her lining such a water basket one day:

She had built a fire and had several small stones about the size of a walnut heating in it. Taking one of the vessels, which was in shape and size very like a demijohn, excepting that the neck and mouth were much longer, she dropped a few pieces of asphaltum within it and as soon as the stones were well heated they were dropped in on top of the asphaltum. They soon melted it, when, resting the bottom of the vessel on the ground, she gave it a rotary motion with both hands until the interior was completely covered with asphaltum.

About a month later the Indian woman was brought back to Santa Barbara and lived with the Nidevers. She was immensely good-humored and spent much time singing and dancing. Many people came to see the famous "lost woman," and attempts were made to understand her language but with no success. The few words that were recorded are *to-co*, a hide; *na-che*, a man; *te-gua*, the sky;

and *pinche*, the body. On the basis of these four words, Kroeber stated that the San Nicolás islanders spoke a Shoshonean dialect.²

The abrupt change of diet from dried seal blubber to the rich and varied Santa Barbara foods proved too much for the Indian woman. She became very weak and, within seven weeks, was dead. The Mission padres were content, however; she had been baptized Juana Maria.

²Bleak, deserted San Nicolás Island is deserted no longer. The U. S. Navy has taken over the island and built a large missile tracking station, doubtless destroying much prehistoric material in the construction of airfields and elaborate military installations. The inevitable scrawled and carved names are appearing in the cave of the killer whales.